

L-46: Indian Society

Future of Caste System | Impact of Buddhism, Jainism, Islam & Christianity

Sarrthi IAS | Anthropology Foundation | Paper 1 (Units 2.1, 3.2, 3.4) | Nataraj Sir

L-46 TOPICS

Part A: Future of Caste

Part B: Buddhism Impact

Part C: Jainism Impact

Part D: Islam Impact

Part E: Christianity Impact

PART A: FUTURE OF CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA

Introduction & Context

- Caste = oldest form of social stratification; shapes social, economic & political life
- Gandhi** (Reformist) vs **Ambedkar** (Abolitionist) — yet caste persists
- Future = tension between **persistence** and **transformation**

M. N. Srinivas

Caste adapts through **Sanskritisation & Westernisation** rather than disappearing

1. Present Reality of Caste

- Castes form **associations** (All India Brahmin Assoc., All India Yadav Assoc.) — pressure groups for jobs, education, political influence
- Caste identity = key basis for **social organisation & political mobilisation**

Counter-View

- Urban IT hiring values **merit** over caste — **Banerjee** study shows limited bias when qualifications are equal
- DICCI** (Dalit Indian Chamber of Commerce & Industry) = Dalit assertion through entrepreneurship

2. Reformist vs Abolitionist Approaches

Approach	Thinker	Argument
Reformist	Gandhi	Purified varna based on qualities, not birth
Abolitionist	 Ambedkar + G.S. Ghurye	Caste is inherently oppressive ; demanded its destruction

Ambedkar — *Annihilation of Caste*

"Political democracy cannot last unless social democracy is achieved."

Counter-View

- Lingayat movement** rejected caste hierarchy outright
- Chandra Bhan Prasad** — "Dalit Capitalism": entrepreneurship as tool for social dignity

3. Remedies Suggested

 **Narmadeshwar Prasad (1957)** — Survey of 1,225 respondents:

Remedy	% Respondents
Expanding education & economic opportunities	39.1%
Promoting inter-caste marriages	35.3%
Ensuring equality of treatment in everyday life	13.4%
Removing untouchability in practice	12.2%

Supporting Data

- Hnatkovska & Lahiri (2012)**: convergence in education & wages for SCs/STs (1980s–2010s)
- Inter-caste marriages: only **5% nationally** (IHDS-2, 2011-12) — rising in urban areas
- NFHS-5**: inter-caste marriages linked to better child nutrition
- Pew Survey 2021**: rigid attitudes but younger/urban Indians show more openness

4. Obstacles & Political Reinforcement

- Mandal Verdict (1992)** — SC upheld caste as basis for reservations → affirmed salience in public policy
- Electoral mobilisation remains deeply caste-based

Pauline Kolenda (1997)

A system shaping Indian society for over 1,000 years cannot vanish within decades

Counter-View

- EWS Quota (2019)**: economic criteria loosening caste as sole axis of affirmative action
- Bihar Caste Survey (2023)**: nuanced socio-economic data for rethinking welfare
- Christophe Jaffrelot**: caste politics has **empowered marginalised groups** — new bargaining power

5. Persistence of Caste Practices

A. Endogamy

Only 5%
of marriages are inter-caste nationally (IHDS-2, 2011-12)

B. Untouchability

27%
of India still practises untouchability (NCAER & University of Maryland)

By Caste	%	By Religion	%
Brahmin	52%	Hindu	35%
Forward	24%	Jain	30%
OBC	15%	Sikh	23%
SC	22%	Muslim	18%
ST	13%	Christian	5%
Others	27%	Buddhist	1%

C. Hereditary Occupations

State	Data
UP	46,000 leather workers → 41,000 are Chamars/Dhusia/Jatava SC sweepers 35-59: 63.4% Balmikis; 15-34: 62% Balmikis Leather (35-59): 88.2% Chamars/Dhusias/Jatavas
Rajasthan	76,000 sweepers → 52,000 Bhangi/Mehtar/Chura
MP	Similar caste-occupation patterns

Counter-View

- Endogamy weakening among educated/urban youth — inter-caste unions via matrimonial platforms
- Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers Act (2013)**
- NAMASTE Scheme (2022)**: mechanises sanitation work
- Technological modernisation erodes caste-based job divisions

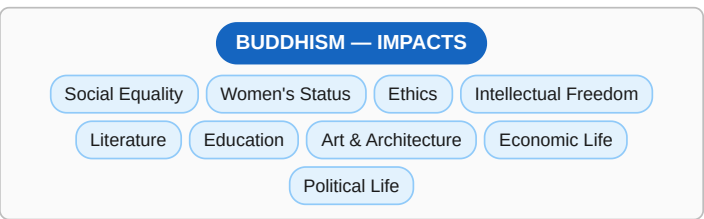
Conclusion: Future of Caste

KEY TAKEAWAY

- Caste will **NOT disappear** — will persist in **new forms**
- Less about **ritual hierarchy** → more about **identity, politics, access to resources**
- Challenge: caste identities must NOT translate into caste inequalities

Andre Beteille
*The tension between **caste and class** will define India's social structure*

PART B: IMPACT OF BUDDHISM ON INDIAN SOCIETY



Context at Buddha's Time

- Society: **static, hierarchical**, dominated by rituals & sacrifices
- Ascribed status > achieved status
- Harsh conditions for women, shudras, some vaishyas
- Buddhism rejected: caste divisions, ritual sacrifices, priestly monopoly
- Preached: **equality, ethics, intellectual freedom**

Essence: Noble Eightfold Path

1. Right Understanding	5. Right Livelihood
2. Right Thought	6. Right Effort
3. Right Speech	7. Right Mindfulness
4. Right Action	8. Right Concentration

Positive Impacts

A. Social Life — Egalitarianism

- Rejected varna system; **anyone could join the Sangha** irrespective of caste/gender

 **R. S. Sharma**
*This shift encouraged recognition of **achieved status** over birth-based status, especially in early urban centres*

B. Status of Women

- Women allowed to become **nuns** and pursue education & spiritual life

 **Uma Chakravarti**
*Works like the **Therigatha** show how early Buddhist nuns expressed **intellectual and spiritual autonomy** — significant step in gender empowerment*

C. Ethics & Morality

- Code of conduct: truth, non-violence, compassion, restraint from theft/alcohol

 **S. Radhakrishnan**
*These principles acted as **civic ethics** — a new form of social control beyond ritual sanction*

D. Intellectual Freedom

- Logic replaced superstition; encouraged **thinking for oneself**
- Written in **Pali** (not Sanskrit) — enabled ordinary people to question rituals & dogma

 **Richard Gombrich**
*Pali canon emphasised **reasoned inquiry**, making debate and questioning the default mode of religious learning*

E. Literature

Text	Significance
Pali Canon (Tipitaka)	Earliest teachings of Buddha
Jataka Tales	Buddha's earlier births; moral lessons
Therigatha	Women's voices & spiritual autonomy
Apabhramsa writings	Enriched Indian linguistic traditions

F. Education

- Buddhist universities: **Nalanda, Vikramshila, Taxila, Valabhi**

R. C. Majumdar
*At Taxila, Buddhist and non-Buddhist subjects (law, medicine, grammar) coexisted — showing **broad scope of education***

G. Art & Architecture

 **A. L. Basham**

Highlights **Gandhara and Mathura schools of art** — flourished due to Buddhist patronage; blending of local and foreign artistic influences

Type	Examples
Pillars	Ashoka Pillars (Bihar, UP)
Stupas	Sanchi, Sarnath, Nalanda
Figurines	Kanheri, Karle, Nasik
Sculptures	Barabar, Ajanta (masterpieces)
Paintings	Ajanta, Ellora (universal attention)
Carvings	On stupa railings & gates — events from Buddha's life

H. Economic Life

- Opposed animal sacrifice; encouraged agriculture; sanctified the cow
- Monasteries = nodes of economic life

 **Upinder Singh**

Monasteries were located along **trade routes** — acted as hubs of commerce and exchange

 **Hermann Kulke**

Monasteries provided **social services** — distributing food and medical care, enhancing welfare functions

I. Political Life

- **Welfare:** Vaishyas & Shudras (looked down upon in Hinduism) converted in large numbers

Romila Thapar

Ashoka's dhamma was not a creed but a model of **ethical kingship** — emphasising welfare and moral governance

- **Non-violence:** Message post-Kalinga War — carved in pillars, spread through *dharma mahamatras*

Negative Impacts of Buddhism

Decline of Vedic Ritual Economy
R. S. Sharma: Rejection of Vedic sacrifices reduced importance of priests → weakened Brahmanical order, created tensions with orthodox groups

Monastic Withdrawal from Society
Romila Thapar: Monasteries led to economic withdrawal from productive activities; monks depended on lay donations → strained agrarian communities

Decline in Military Strength
Emphasis on non-aggression, non-violence, asceticism → weakened militancy → India fell prey to foreign invaders → centuries of political subjugation

Spread of Buddhism

Outside India (via Ashoka)

- Spread through **dharma mahamatras**
- **Mahavamsa:** In 17th year of Ashoka's reign, after 3rd Buddhist Council → missionaries sent to **9 parts of the world**
- Daughter **Sanghamitra** & son **Mahindra** → spread Buddhism in Sri Lanka

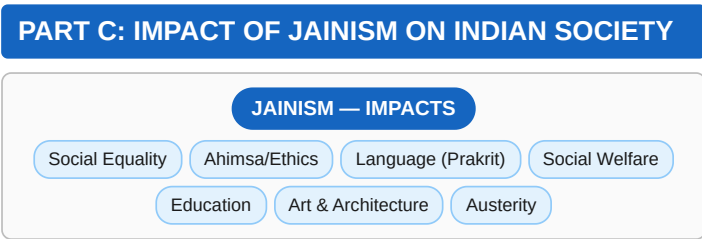
Decline within India

- Became primarily monastic → lost touch with lay supporters
- Monasteries became wealthy — employed indentured slaves & paid labourers
- Muslim invaders sacked monasteries (12th–13th century) → no revival until 20th century

20th Century Revival

Year	Institution/Event
1891	Maha Bodhi Society
1892	Bengal Buddhist Association
1898	Young Men's Buddhist Association
1950s	Ambedkar — promoted conversion for Dalits (influenced by Dharmanand Kosambi & Lakshmi Narasu)

- **Dalit Buddhist Movement** — most successful in **Maharashtra**
- Ambedkar's "**Neo Buddhism**": strong element of social & political protest against Hinduism and caste system



Context & Essence

- Oldest **sramana** tradition; emerged **6th century BCE** alongside Buddhism
- Questioned Vedic orthodoxy; emphasis on **ahimsa**, **austerity**, **spiritual discipline**

Three Jewels (Ratnatraya)

Jewel	Meaning
Samyak Darshan	Right Faith
Samyak Jnana	Right Knowledge
Samyak Charitra	Right Conduct

All three required for spiritual liberation — none can exist without the others

Five Maha-vratas (Great Vows)

#	Vow	Meaning
1	Ahimsa	Non-violence
2	Satya	Truth
3	Achaurya/Asteya	Non-stealing
4	Aparigraha	Non-possession/Non-attachment
5	Brahmacharya	Celibacy/Chastity

Positive Impacts

A. Social Equality

- Rejects caste system; advocates equality; monastic communities don't discriminate

 **Romila Thapar**

*Such sectarian movements **challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy** and offered parallel paths of dignity*

B. Ethical Values & Ahimsa

- Strong emphasis on non-violence → promoted compassion for all living beings
- Jains adhere to vegetarian lifestyle; engage in charitable activities

 **A. L. Basham**

*Jain ascetic ideals of **restraint and compassion** = one of the strongest **moral vocabularies** of ancient India*

C. Language

- Contributed to evolution of **Prakrit language** — designed for accessibility to common people

Romila Thapar

*This widened the reading public and **democratised learning***

D. Social Welfare Initiatives

- Construction of **dharamshalas** (pilgrims' rest houses) near pilgrimage destinations

 **R. C. Majumdar**

*Mercantile patronage made Jain temples and inns **civic hubs***

E. Education & Scholarship

- Long tradition of scholarship; Jain monks contributed to intellectual development
- Tattvartha Sutra**: instrumental in shaping philosophical discussions

F. Art & Architecture

Form	Examples
Rock-cut caves	Badami, Aihole, Ajanta, Ellora, Elephanta, Aurangabad, Mamallapuram
Temple	Gommateshwara Bahubali statue at Shravanabelagola
Paintings	Kalpa Sutra — biographies of Tirthankaras (Parshvanatha & Mahavira)

CASE STUDY: ELLORA COMPLEX

Unique artistic creation with sanctuaries devoted to Buddhism, Hinduism & Jainism — illustrates the **spirit of tolerance** characteristic of ancient India (UNESCO World Heritage)

G. Principles of Austerity

- Promoted: voluntary simplicity, fasting, humility, selfless service, pursuit of knowledge, meditation

Spread of Jainism

- Not widely embraced — stringent orthodoxy, affinity to Brahmanism, non-missionary spirit
- Most converts from **Vaishya** community
- India's **6th largest religion**

44,51,753

Jains in India (2011 Census) — majority in Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP

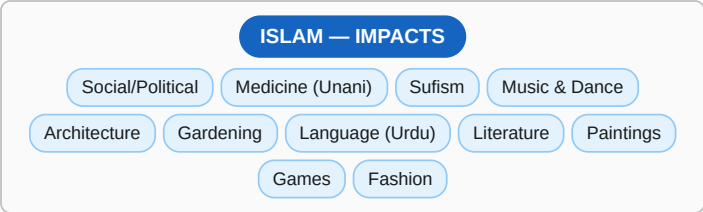
Influence far greater than numbers suggest

Criticisms & Limitations

Social Isolation

 **Romila Thapar**: Jainism's strict commitment to ahimsa & ritual purity led to **social separation and isolation** of Jain communities — weakened **social cohesion** with other groups

PART D: IMPACT OF ISLAM ON INDIAN SOCIETY



Entry & Social/Political Life

- Entered India from **7th century onwards** — through trade, migration, political expansion
- Many from deprived castes attracted to Islam
- Impact on constitution: Hindu Marriage Act & Succession Act
- Affected position of women — birth of girl considered inauspicious (spread to some Hindu communities)

 **Harbans Mukhia**

*Mohammed preached **doctrine of one God** in polytheistic Arabia — "the concept of one god meant the concept of **social equality**"*

 **Dr. Tara Chand**

*Emphasised the message of **sulhe-kul** ("peace for all and complete peace") of the Muslim Sufi Silsilah (mystic orders)*

Medicine

- Introduced **Unani system of medicine** in India
- Yunani** = "Greek" — Perso-Arabic system based on teachings of **Hippocrates & Galen**

Sufism

- Mystical Islamic belief — Muslims seek truth of divine love through **direct personal experience of God**

Richard Eaton

*Sufi saints often integrated local practices, producing a **syncretic culture***

CASE STUDY: NIZAMUDDIN AULIYA (1238-1325 CE)

Dargah in Delhi — visited by thousands every week; known for evening **qawwali** devotional music sessions. Symbol of Islamic-Indian syncretism.

Music & Dance

 **B. S. Upadhyaya**

Feeders of Indian Culture (1973) — detailed contribution of Islam & Muslims to Indian music

Contribution	Details
Instruments	Sitar & Tabla brought by Muslims
Devotional music	Qawwali
Dance	Kathak (Indo-Persian) — unique: both Hindu & Muslim gharanas; Urdu Ghazals + Mughal instruments
Great contributor	Amir Khusro

Architecture

- Introduced **domes, minarets, turrets, arches**
- Examples: **Taj Mahal, Buland Darwaza, Alai Darwaza**

 **Rosherduddin Khan**
***Khanqahs** (monasteries) "provided refuge to the oppressed and wretched... irrespective of caste and creed"*

Gardening, Language & Literature

Domain	Contribution
Gardening	Charbagh style — Persian quadrilateral garden based on 4 gardens of Paradise (Quran); divided by walkways/flowing water
Language	Synthesis of Islam & Hinduism → birth of Urdu Great contributor:  Mirza Ghalib
Literature	Historiography: Babarnama, Akbarnama, Ain-i-Akbari Frances Pritchett : Persian traditions enriched Indian languages

Paintings, Games & Fashion

Domain	Details
Paintings	Mughal miniature painting — emerged from Persian miniature (Chinese origin); confined to book illustrations or muraqqa albums; Jahangir's reign = zenith
Games	Hunting, hawking, kite-flying, Shatranj (chess) — from Indian chaturanga ; reached Europe via Muslim Al-Andalus (10th century)
Fashion	Mughal dress adopted by Hindu rulers; Nose ring (Nath) → symbol of Hindu marriage (from Muslim traditions)

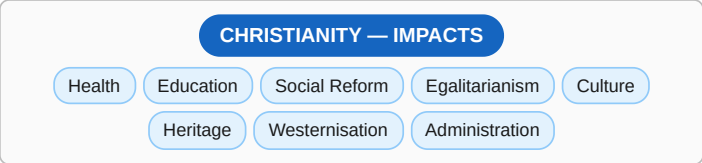
Negative Impacts

Purdah & Women's Subordination
Romila Thapar: Rigid practices like **purdah** contributed to subordination of women

Conversion Tensions
K. S. Lal: Mass conversions sometimes caused **social tensions** between communities

Religious Orthodoxy
Strict enforcement in certain regimes narrowed religious tolerance — contrasts with syncretic Sufi stream

PART E: IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY ON INDIAN SOCIETY



Entry & Essence

- Entered India **52 AD** — arrival of **St. Thomas** on Malabar Coast
- Real spread: **European missionaries from 16th century** onwards
- Shaped: education, healthcare, social reforms, architecture, culture

 **Victor D'Souza**
*"In India, Christianity has been one of the important factors of **modernization and economic development** through the social values it has legitimized"*

Essence of Christianity

- Universal brotherhood
- Egalitarian outlook
- Service of the under-privileged

Positive Impacts

A. Health Initiatives

- Established hospitals — pioneered social welfare in gaps of government reach
- Notable in **North-East India**
- CMC Vellore** = legacy of missionary health service

William Sweet
*Christian missions institutionalised hospitals and clinics, making **modern medicine accessible***

B. Educational Impact

- Introduced **English** as medium of instruction → unifying language among Western-educated
- Established schools where government reach was limited

92%
literacy in Mizoram — attributed to Christian missions

Teotonio R. de Souza
*Missionaries introduced **modern education and literacy**, shaping India's early Western-educated elite*

 **Arun Shourie**
*(Critical but useful to cite) Missionary education had both **reformist and cultural assimilationist** aims*

C. Social Reforms & Opposition to Caste

- Christian teachings influenced educated individuals to challenge Hindu caste system → significant socio-religious reforms

John C. B. Webster
*Emphasized missionary efforts in challenging **untouchability** and promoting **social justice***

D. Cultural Contributions

Domain	Examples
Architecture	Basilica of Bom Jesus , Goa
Music	Orchestra, guitar, piano introduced
Clothing	Western formals became mainstream

E. Heritage Rediscovery

Who	Year	Discovery
Henry Taylor	1818	Rediscovered Sanchi Stupa
John Smith	1819	Stumbled upon Ajanta Caves
James Prinsep	1837	Deciphered Brahmi script

F. Westernisation & Administration

 **B. B. Misra**
*Christianity acted as a channel of **Western political ideas** — paving the way for liberalism and democratic institutions*

- Influenced adoption of **Legislature, Executive, Judiciary** (3 branches from European models)
- Role in unification of India's administrative systems under British colonial rule

Negative Impacts

Conversion Conflicts

 **Susan Bayly:** Disputes over conversion created **localised social strife**

Example: **Kandhamal violence (2008)**, Odisha

Cultural Assimilation & Loss

 **Teotonio R. de Souza:** Aggressive cultural assimilation sometimes **eroded indigenous practices** — European customs replaced traditional Indian ways of life

Summary

- 2.3%** of Indian population — yet influence on education, healthcare, social reforms, art & politics = **profound**
- From **Mother Teresa's** humanitarian work to **Mizoram's literacy success**
 - Legacy of social change, cultural enrichment & spiritual inspiration

COMPARATIVE: ALL FOUR RELIGIONS				
Dimension	Buddhism	Jainism	Islam	Christianity
Entry/Origin	6th c. BCE India	6th c. BCE India	7th c. CE (trade/migration)	5th c. CE (Roman Empire)
Core Message	Eightfold Path; equality	Ratnatraya + Ahimsa	One God = equality; Sulhe-kul	Love God & neighbor
Social Impact	Rejected varna; Sangha open to all	Rejected caste; non-discrimination	Attracted deprived castes; purdah	Abolished slavery; inspired social reforms
Education	Nalanda, Taxila, Vikramshila	Tattvartha Sutra; scholarship tradition	Historiography; Babarnama	Monastic schools; universities
Art/Architecture	Gandhara/Mathura; stupas; Ajanta	Ellora; Gommateshwara; Kalpa Sutra	Domes/arches; Taj Mahal; miniatures	Cathedrals; Gothic architecture; religious art
Language	Pali — democratised	Prakrit — democratised	Urdu — synthesis	Latin — liturgical; vernacular Bibles
Negative	Military decline; monastic withdrawal	Social isolation	Purdah; conversion tensions	Crusades; religious wars

QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

L-46: Future of Caste | Impact of Religions on Indian Society

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Case Studies / Data
Future of Caste	Persistence + transformation; endogamy; political reinforcement; identity-based not ritual-based; caste ≠ disappearing	Srinivas (Sanskritisation); Ambedkar (Annihilation); Beteille (caste vs class); Kolenda (1000 yrs); Jaffrelot (empowerment); Narmadeshwar Prasad (survey)	DICCI; All India Yadav Assoc.; EWS quota 2019; Bihar Survey 2023	5% inter-caste marriages (IHDS-2); 27% untouchability (NCAER); UP leather workers; Mandal 1992; NAMASTE 2022
Buddhism	Egalitarianism; achieved status; women nuns; civic ethics; Pali; Eightfold Path; trade-route monasteries; ethical kingship; military decline	R.S. Sharma (achieved status); Uma Chakravarti (Therigatha); Radhakrishnan (civic ethics); Gombrich (reasoned inquiry); Basham (Gandhara/Mathura); Upinder Singh (trade); Kulke (welfare); Thapar (dhamma); Majumdar (Taxila)	Nalanda; Sanchi; Ajanta; Pali Canon; Jataka; Maha Bodhi Society	Neo-Buddhism (Ambedkar-Maharashtra); Sanghamitra+Mahindra → Sri Lanka; 20th c. revival; Kalinga War → non-violence
Jainism	Ratnatraya; 5 Maha-vratas; ahimsa; Prakrit; dharamshalas; austerity; non-missionary; 6th largest religion	Romila Thapar (challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy + social isolation); Basham (moral vocabulary); R.C. Majumdar (civic hubs)	Ellora complex; Gommateshwara; Kalpa Sutra; Tattvartha Sutra	44,51,753 Jains (2011 Census); Maharashtra/Rajasthan/Gujarat/MP majority; Vaishya converts
Islam	One God = equality; Sufism-syncretism; Unani medicine; Urdu; domes/arches; Charbagh; Kathak; miniature painting; purdah	Harbans Mukhia (one God); Tara Chand (sulhe-kul); Richard Eaton (syncretic); B.S. Upadhyaya (music); Rosherduddin Khan (khanqahs); Frances Pritchett (Persian literary); K.S. Lal (tensions); Romila Thapar (purdah)	Nizamuddin Auliya; Taj Mahal; Sitar/Tabla; Qawwali; Amir Khusro; Mirza Ghalib; Shatranj; Nath (nose ring)	Kathak: Hindu + Muslim gharanas; Mughal miniatures peaked under Jahangir; Chess via Al-Andalus 10th c.
Christianity	52 AD St. Thomas; universal brotherhood; health + education pioneer; English medium; heritage rediscovery; Westernisation channel; conversion conflicts	Victor D'Souza (modernisation); Sweet (hospitals); Teotonio de Souza (education + cultural loss); Arun Shourie (assimilationist); Webster (anti-untouchability); B.B. Misra (political ideas); Susan Bayly (conversion strife)	CMC Vellore; Basilica Bom Jesus; Mizoram 92% literacy; guitar/piano; Mother Teresa	Kandhamal violence 2008 (Odisha); 2.3% population but disproportionate influence; Sanchi (1818), Ajanta (1819), Brahmi (1837)

Master Scholar Quick-Reference

Scholar	Key Argument (One-liner)
M. N. Srinivas	Caste adapts via Sanskritisation & Westernisation
Andre Beteille	Caste vs class tension defines India's structure
Pauline Kolenda	1000-year system won't vanish in decades
Christophe Jaffrelot	Caste politics empowered marginalised groups
R. S. Sharma	Buddhism: achieved > ascribed status; weakened Vedic economy
Uma Chakravarti	Therigatha shows Buddhist nuns' autonomy
Romila Thapar	Ashoka's dhamma = ethical kingship; Jainism challenged orthodoxy; purdah → women's subordination
A. L. Basham	Gandhara/Mathura art; Jain moral vocabulary
Harbans Mukhia	One God = social equality
Dr. Tara Chand	Sufi message of sulhe-kul (universal peace)
Richard Eaton	Sufis integrated local practices → syncretic culture
Victor D'Souza	Christianity = modernisation & economic development
B. B. Misra	Christianity channelled Western political ideas (liberalism)

MNEMONIC: 4 RELIGIONS' CORE IMPACT (BEJC)

Buddhism = Equality + Ethics | Jainism = Ahimsa + Austerity | Islam = Syncretism + Aesthetics | Christianity = Modernisation + Education

MNEMONIC: CASTE PERSISTENCE FACTORS (EPE)

Endogamy (5% inter-caste) + Politics (Mandal, mobilisation) + Entrenched attitudes (27% untouchability)